encountered new experiences, both human (philosophers) and natural (elephants), which seemed to deeply impress him. At the River Hydaspes (Jhelum), he faced the local king Porus in battle under torrential weather conditions. Alexander's plans, Porus's counters, and their tactical ingenuity were described by Greek chroniclers, who add that Porus surrendered, and Alexander claimed suzerainty over his realm. The Macedonian leader then proceeded east, although the exact route was difficult to determine. At a point believed to be the banks of the Beas River, his forces refused to advance further. Struggling with heat and disease, Alexander's armies marched south down the Indus and retreated west. [7]

Alexander's invasion of Punjab was relatively brief, but it resulted in a long-term Greek cultural presence around what is today Afghanistan and north-western India under the Seleucids. As a consequence, India came into direct contact with the Hellenistic (Greek-speaking) world. From the third to the first century BCE, Bactrian Greek kingdoms maintained a Greek cultural, artistic, and linguistic heritage in and around northwest India, as evident in surviving statuary and coinage. The Greeks Ctesias and Megasthenes wrote works titled *Indica*, although neither survives in their entirety. Ctesias, writing before Alexander's conquests, reflected Persian views of India, with frequently fantastical and absurd descriptions. Megasthenes was a Greek ambassador of Seleucus Nicator to the court of Chandragupta, and while his characterization of India heavily informed later Hellenistic and Roman writers, many ancient writers also cast severe doubts on the accuracy of his accounts. [8]

It was also in the aftermath of Alexander's invasion in the late fourth century BCE that the Mauryas rose to power in north-central India. The Emperor Ashoka—grandson of the dynastic founder Chandragupta—built a legacy as a patron and proselytizer of Buddhism. The life of Ashoka, often referred to in inscriptions as Piyadasi Devanampiya, is rather poorly recorded in historical literature. Surviving texts associated with Mauryan rule such as the *Ashokavadana* were likely written much later. However, Ashoka's plentiful edicts—engraved across India on rocks or pillars—leave a remarkable and direct legacy of his governance philosophy. They were